

****Long Live The Emperor****

Hecate's Perspective

Centuries had drifted by since I wed our savior, yet the time we'd shared could be counted on one hand. Shadows stretched across the obsidian throne room as I turned to him, the lingering presence of the envoy's fear still clinging to the air like static. "Darling, shall I prepare the resting quarters?" I inquired, my voice echoing faintly against the cavernous walls.

He glanced at me, his eyes glowing crimson—a telltale sign of mana coursing through his veins. The ambient light refracted unnaturally around him, bending as if repelled by the raw energy he barely restrained. "I need to blow off steam first," he replied, his tone a low rumble that vibrated in the marrow of my bones. "An arena. Preferably with live targets."

I smirked, the irony bitter on my tongue. "I shall request death-row prisoners from the warden. The usual terms, my lord? Their freedom if they prevail?" The notion was laughable, of course. No mortal could withstand even a flicker of his true power.

As the court adjourned, I drifted toward Elfona, her silver hair cascading like liquid moonlight over the council table. Her posture betrayed unease, fingers tracing the ancient runes carved into the wood. "Lady of Flowers," I murmured, settling beside her. "You seem... troubled."

Her gaze remained fixed on the distant horizon beyond the stained-glass windows. "That hero," she began, voice quivering with uncharacteristic fragility. "A child torn from his world, fed divine promises, only to be slaughtered by the one we call *lord*. His sole crime was existence. Does that not... unsettle you?"

I studied her profile, the faint glow of her All-Seeing Eye pulsing beneath her brow. "Sometimes the truth remains veiled," I replied, my voice softening. "But I'll never doubt the one who battled the world itself, who slaughtered legions of monsters to forge this nation."

Her laugh was hollow, devoid of mirth. “You misunderstand, Hecate.” She turned to me, her irises flickering with visions beyond mortal comprehension. “Lord Charlie ceased to be *human* long ago. My Clairvoyance reveals neither man nor monster. His existence has crystallized into... a fundamental law. Immutable. Eternal.” A shiver rippled through her, as if the admission physically pained her. “We three—you, Liza, and I—could unravel galaxies. Yet *he* holds power to fracture the Yggdrasil itself. No mortal should wield such might. No *being*, however ancient, should exist without counterbalance.”

Her words hung in the air, thick as funeral incense. The blue-flame sconces dimmed, as though the castle itself recoiled from her blasphemy. “And his suffering...” she continued, her voice fraying. “Eons of isolation, of wars waged alone... It’s twisted him into something detached from morality itself. Even his motto—*Sic Semper Tyrannis*—reeks of paradox. Who plays the tyrant now?”

I leaned closer, the scent of wilted roses clinging to her robes. “What would you have us do, then?” The question emerged sharper than intended, edged with unease I couldn’t fully mask.

Elfona’s eyes met mine, twin voids shimmering with the weight of foresight. “What *can* we do?” she whispered. “When the arbiter of fate becomes the storm?”

Silence descended, heavy and suffocating. Somewhere in the castle depths, a gong tolled—the summoning bell for the condemned. The games would soon begin. Yet as I rose to attend my lord, Elfona’s warning coiled around my thoughts like a serpent, its venom seeping slowly, irrevocably, into the cracks of my resolve.

It never ceased to surprise me how swiftly devotees of the Lord mobilized. Within moments of my request, a maid returned with a nod—the prisoners were ready. The courtyard had already been transformed into a barren arena, its dirt floor scorched by prior spectacles and encircled by seamless stone walls towering thirty feet high. No blade of grass dared grow here; even the air tasted metallic, tinged with old blood and ozone.

Before I could survey the preparations further, Charlie strode into the arena. Gone was his ornate coat, replaced by the simple attire he'd designed centuries ago: a black linen shirt, faded jeans, and boots worn smooth by time. The artisans still replicated them flawlessly, a testament to his lingering influence. Yet even without my All-Seeing Eye, I felt the thrum of his power—raw mana bleeding from his pores, warping the air itself into a suffocating haze. The ground crackled faintly beneath his steps, as though the earth feared to bear his weight.

A half-elf referee, pale and sweating, stepped forward. His fingers clutched a mana-reinforced ledger like a lifeline. "Prisoner 4756," he announced, voice trembling slightly. "A half-vampire serial murderer. Twenty-three confirmed kills. No remorse. No... *redeeming qualities*." The last phrase dripped with bureaucratic disdain.

The iron gates groaned open. Out stepped the condemned—a wiry man clad in the standard-issue brown tunic and trousers of our garrison, twin serrated knives strapped to his hips. His posture radiated cold defiance, lips curled in a smirk that revealed elongated canines. Half-vampire, yes, but his human arrogance remained intact. His eyes swept the arena, lingering on Charlie with a predator's calculating gleam.

I almost pitied him. Almost.

The referee raised a shaking hand. "Combat commences on the third bell. Terms remain as ordained: survive five minutes, and freedom is granted." A hollow promise. The bells tolled—once, twice—and the prisoner lunged, knives glinting like fangs in the pallid light.

Charlie did not move.

The third bell rang.